NOCTURNE

After exposing a powerful family secret, a haunted heiress enters a corporate identity-erasure facility where patients are renamed, rewritten, and spiritually harvested, only to discover she may be the facility's first buried subject, a forgotten “black goddess” whose erased memories could destroy the cult-machine that created her.

Written by

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FADE IN:

INT. PROFESSOR SHIN'S APARTMENT - NIGHT

A sparse, modern Tokyo high-rise. Concrete and teak and a window cracked to the city hum.

A table for two. Ceramic bowls of curry steam. Sake breathes in the bottle.

The curry is uneven. Too much cumin, rice stuck to the pot rim.

He cooked it himself.

The apartment carries the small kindnesses of someone who lives alone but wishes he did not.

A second toothbrush in the bathroom cup. Dried out. Months old.

Books stacked by the bed. A biography of Mishima, a train schedule.

A water-stained copy of a paper he never published.

An old record turns in the corner. Three notes rise and fall. The same phrase, over and over.

Shin hums along under his breath. He doesn't notice he's doing it.

AKIRA (26) sits across from PROFESSOR SHIN (40s). Her posture precise, lipstick too dark for the room.

His wedding ring catches the overhead light. Pressed collar knotted tight all evening.

They eat. The silence between them is old and comfortable.

SHIN
I burned the garlic again.

AKIRA
I noticed.

SHIN
You could've said something.

AKIRA
And miss you pretending it's a technique?

His mouth twitches. Almost. She lifts the sake and pours for him. The wrong direction. He takes it anyway.

SHIN
You look like you haven't slept in a week.

AKIRA
Has it been a week?

SHIN
You're deflecting.

AKIRA
You're counting.

Setting down his chopsticks, he studies her. The way he reads a headline he knows will be retracted.

SHIN
Eat. It's terrible, but it's food.

She eats. He watches her do it. Something in him loosens when she takes a second bite.

AKIRA
You always cook when you're worried.

SHIN
I always cook when I'm hungry.

AKIRA
You're deflecting.

SHIN
I learned from the best.

A beat of quiet. Chopsticks on ceramic. The radiator ticking. Rain against glass.

Shin clears her empty bowl without asking.

Letting him take it, she holds the ceramic a half-second longer than necessary. Then releases.

He returns. His laptop sits on the counter behind him, screen dimmed.

A headline visible: KAWASAKI GROUP HEIRESS. Neither of them has looked at it all night.

SHIN (CONT'D)
I got a call yesterday.

AKIRA
From?

SHIN
No name. The number was blocked. Polite voice. Very polite. Asked if I'd considered taking a sabbatical.

His hands are steady. His voice is not.

AKIRA
A sabbatical.

SHIN
From the Kawasaki research specifically.

She sets down her sake.

AKIRA
What did you say?

SHIN
I said I'd think about it. Then I changed my locks and cooked you dinner.

Sake, steam, the scratched teak table. The warmth still here.

AKIRA
You don't have to pretend we're equals when you pour.

SHIN
I'm not pretending.

She chews. He watches.

AKIRA
You heard what they're saying?

SHIN
They always say something.

AKIRA
You didn't deny it.

Shin's mouth thins. The almost-smile from before.

SHIN
That's not the same as confirming.

Silence. Steam fogs her glasses. Food pushed around the bowl.

SHIN (CONT'D)
I always liked how you ask questions like you already know the answer.

AKIRA
I already know what I'm worth to you.

SHIN
That's not fair.

AKIRA
That's not a denial.

Reaching across the table, he wipes curry from her lip with his thumb.

Fingers tighten on the chopsticks — the only tell.

SHIN
You should learn to keep secrets if you want to stay important.

He smiles. Drawing blood.

The warmth drains from the room by degrees.

Shin's chopsticks still. He sets them down precisely.

Outside, the city hums. In here, the frequency has changed.

Her eyes glass. Never break. She stands. Coat from the chair.

SHIN (CONT'D)
Akira.

She pauses at the door. Back to him.

SHIN (CONT'D)
Be careful with whatever you're about to do.

The door closes behind her. Shin sits alone. The curry cools. The headline glows.

INT. AKIRA'S APARTMENT - NIGHT

Fingers open a folder. Confidential documents. Names and transfers.

She slides them into a scanner. Movements slow and controlled.

Her email open on the screen. No subject line. No body. Attachment loaded, recipient set.

On the desk beside the scanner, a pressed wildflower between sheets of wax paper. Stems brown and brittle.

Reaching for it, she touches one petal. Light enough that it doesn't crumble. Her hand lingers. Then pulls back.

A sound from the walls. A child's laugh, faint. Or the building settling. Gone before she places it.

Her left hand opens and closes. A tic. Unconscious.

Typing into the message body:

I wanted to be believed. But more than that, I wanted to be impossible to ignore.

Stares at the words. Selects all. Deletes.

The cursor blinks on the empty field. Her mouse hovers over SEND.

EXT. CREEK - DAY

Two girls barefoot in late afternoon light. One chases the other through shallow water. Breathless.

The younger one turns. Braid swinging. Mouth open in a laugh that belongs to a different life.

INT. AKIRA'S APARTMENT - NIGHT

Akira stares at the screen. A shape in the dark glass. A braid. Gone before it registers.

She clicks SEND.

Her phone buzzes on the desk. Unknown number.

A text. Three words: They know. Akira.

She reads it twice. Deletes it.

Opens a second browser tab. A Nocturne Ltd. intake form. Pre-filled.

Her photograph already uploaded. She has been planning this for weeks.

The cursor blinks on the submission button. She does not hesitate.

INT. AKIRA'S APARTMENT - BATHROOM - NIGHT

A match held to the folder. Flame climbs fast.

Dropped in the sink. Paper blackens, curls, chokes. Smoke fills the small room.

INT. SUBWAY CAR - NIGHT

Akira sits alone. Coat pulled tight, feet bare on the floor. Shoes left somewhere she will not return to.

Fluorescent lights stutter overhead. A rhythm like a failing heartbeat.

Coat open. Beneath the blouse, a scar traces her ribs. Fingers follow it. Taking inventory.

Her reflection floats in the dark glass. Pale, wavering.

Watching her own eyes in the dark glass. Jaw tightens. Fists curl on her lap.

The lights stutter again. Her reflection lags a half-second behind. Then catches up.

She blinks. Counts to three. Her reflection blinks on two.

The car empties at Roppongi. She stays seated.

Her hands rest on her thighs. The scars face upward. A private reading.

The tunnel swallows the light. For four seconds she has no reflection at all.

A blink. Straightening. The train pulls forward.

EXT. NOCTURNE LTD. HEADQUARTERS - NIGHT

A nondescript building. Corporate. Built to be passed without seeing.

Akira stands outside, soaked. Barefoot on concrete. Rain runs down her face. She lets it.

Her hand goes to the buzzer without searching. The exact height. The exact position.

A SPEAKER crackles beside the door.

VOICE
Name?

AKIRA
Akira Kawasaki.

The door clicks open.

INT. NOCTURNE LTD. - LOBBY - NIGHT

Fluorescent and cold. No reception desk.

REI MIKAMI (30s) waits in a pressed suit. Pen in hand, notebook open.

The smile he gives her is thin. Professional.

Akira steps inside. Her eyes flick to the WALL-MOUNTED DISPLAY — a looped welcome screen.

INSERT - THE SCREEN:

WELCOME TO NOCTURNE LTD.

The text cycles through three languages. Japanese. English. A third she does not recognize.

Below the display, a wall panel has been removed and replaced. The paint does not match.

Where a government seal hung, the outline remains. A faded rectangle of cleaner paint.

In the lower corner of the display, a glyph pulses once. □□. Then the screen resets.

PARTICIPATION IS VOLUNTARY.

NOCTURNE LTD. IS NOT LIABLE UNDER NATIONAL OR INTERNATIONAL JURISDICTION.

Below the display, etched in the glass, a government seal. Partially scraped away. Someone tried to erase it.

Her eyes linger.

REI
You're on time. That distinction is noted in your intake assessment.

She nods. Stays standing.

AKIRA
What happens now?

REI
We begin. The facility has been expecting you.

He clicks his pen. The sound carries.

The display stutters. A black glyph flashes across the screen for a single frame — ancient, insect-like: □□.

Akira tenses. Eyes narrow.

REI (CONT'D)
Breathe.

Casual. The way a doctor says it before drawing blood.

Exhaling, she loosens. The tension drains. Or she pushes it down.

REI (CONT'D)
Legacy code. Old systems bleeding through.

AKIRA
How old?

REI
Before my tenure. A prior administration’s methodology.

The screen clears. Corporate blue. Akira says nothing. But she has seen it.

INT. NOCTURNE LTD. - HALLWAY - MOMENTS LATER

Long corridor. White tile, stainless steel. Electricity hums beneath the silence.

Akira walks beside Rei. Footsteps swallowed by the floor.

REI
Phones. Wallet. Identification. Standard intake compliance, no exceptions.

She hands everything over without protest. Even the necklace — a tiny jade cicada.

Rei clocks it. Turns it in his fingers.

REI (CONT’D)
Sentimental? We catalog personal effects for the duration of your residency.

AKIRA
It was my sister's.

REI
Not anymore. Effective upon intake, all prior attachments are suspended.

He drops it into a plastic envelope. Seals it.

Her fingers stay in the air where it was. Then close.

A door ahead hisses open.

INT. NOCTURNE LTD. - INDUCTION ROOM - NIGHT

A room built to look medical. That cold-warm confusion of hotels and funeral homes.

YUMI TAKEDA (late 20s) stands behind a terminal. Hair too neat. Nails too clean.

She looks up as Akira enters. Her hand pauses on the keyboard. Half a second. Then resumes.

YUMI
Remove your clothing to undergarments for the preliminary scan.

Akira stands still.

YUMI (CONT'D)
You reviewed the complete intake documentation?

AKIRA
I read it. Did you write it?

YUMI
Parts of it.

AKIRA
Which parts?

Silence. Akira takes her time. Blazer. Blouse. Skirt. Each item folded precisely, laid on the chair.

REI
Everything from this point is recorded. Understood?

AKIRA
And what's that?

Rei meets her gaze. Holds it. Akira nods once.

AKIRA (CONT'D)
You want a confession?

YUMI
The facility requires your explicit permission for each procedural stage.

Stepping forward with a scanner, Yumi passes it over Akira's body.

The screen behind her pulses. Brainwave graphs, thermal overlays. Kanji in red.

The scanner crosses Akira's left temple. A reading spikes.

Yumi's hand stops. Eyes flick to the screen.

Half a second. Recognition, then nothing. She adjusts the scanner's frequency. The spike flattens.

Rei watches from across the room. He saw Yumi pause. He files it.

YUMI (CONT'D)
No pacemaker. No pregnancy. No record of psychiatric detainment.

REI
Physical trauma. Lower left thoracic scarring.

AKIRA
Knife.

YUMI
Yours?

AKIRA
(quiet)
No.

Her pen stays still.

Rei slides a folder toward her. Thick, paper-clipped.

REI
Sign and thumbprint. You may choose to speak a final sentence into record.

Akira flips through the pages. Eyes pause at one section: MOTIVE.

Her pen hovers.

AKIRA
I was the wrong story in the right family.

She signs. Presses her thumb.

Yumi clicks something. The lights shift cooler.

YUMI
Transfer protocol initiates now.
Maintain your current position.

A door slides open behind them. Faint sound of rain. No exit sign.

Akira steps forward. Eyes ahead.

INT. NOCTURNE LTD. - OBSERVATION SUITE - NIGHT

A bank of monitors. Yumi and Rei watch Akira disappear down the corridor beyond.

The feed cuts. Soundless. Akira shrinking toward the vanishing point.

YUMI
She hasn’t been briefed. Her awareness sits below threshold.

REI
None of them do. Consent is the ceremony. The outcome was decided before you arrived.

He watches the dark feed. Calm.

REI (CONT’D)
What we remove was already hurting them. We simply document the relief.

Yumi closes the terminal. Her fingers press the space where Akira's scan data was. Linger there.

YUMI
(low)
Her temporal readings spiked during the scan. The signal wasn't responding to stimuli. It was generating from inside her.

REI
Meaning? Clarify your statement for the diagnostic record.

YUMI
I’ve seen this.

Rei waits.

YUMI (CONT’D)
It's nothing. Hardware calibration.

One exhale. Controlled.

YUMI (CONT’D)
Good.

She turns. Walks away, leaving only static behind her.

INT. NOCTURNE LTD. - TRANSFER CORRIDOR - NIGHT

Dim and narrow. A metallic hum. Akira walks flanked by two silent attendants.

Ahead, another subject. Male, mid-30s. Sweat through his gown. A numbered scar on his inner wrist. Healed, old, precise.

He sees Akira. Snaps.

SUBJECT
No! This isn't what they said!

He spins. Elbow into one attendant's throat. The man drops.

Screams echo down the corridor. A strobe hits — harsh, white, pulsing.

Lunging forward, the second attendant tackles him. A syringe hits the floor. Shatters.

Akira stops. Unmoving.

The subject locks eyes with her. Bloody and wild.

SUBJECT (CONT’D)
Don't let them—

Yanked backward. His scream cuts off.

Silence. Then the hum returns.

Akira's gaze drops to the floor. A smear of blood. Beside it, a laminated card. Numbered. Identical to hers.

Walking. The corridor swallowing her footsteps. A door opens ahead.

INT. NOCTURNE LTD. - ORIENTATION ROOM - NIGHT

Clinical, soundproofed. Soft earth-toned walls, artificial plants. A screen on the far wall — corporate video frozen mid-frame.

A constant drone. The inside of a machine.

Akira sits alone at a round table. Posture perfect, hands trembling beneath the edge. A CAMERA blinks red above her.

A speaker in the ceiling crackles. Rei's voice, filtered through static.

REI
Whenever you're prepared to proceed, Ms. Kawasaki. The intake protocol has no time limit.

AKIRA
Does it matter what I say?

REI
It's your record. The institution requires your verbal confirmation of each entry.

AKIRA
My name is Akira Kawasaki. Voluntary relocation under Nocturne Ltd.

Her voice catches on voluntary. Half a second. Then pushes through.

AKIRA (CONT'D)
I relinquish legal identity, familial ties, and all forms of digital presence...

A sound through the vents. A child's laugh, soft. It does not belong in this room. Akira turns. Reflexive.

The room is still.

INT. NOCTURNE LTD. - COMMON ROOM - NIGHT

A cafeteria space. Pale wood, soft music through recessed speakers. Everything too clean.

People in groups of twos and threes. Smiling. Too still.

Akira enters. Her shoes make no sound on the vinyl. The room registers her presence. No one looks.

Yumi emerges from the corner.

YUMI
Relax. They're friendly, in theory.

AKIRA
Do they speak?

YUMI
Only if you already know what they'll say.

Yumi leads her to a small circular table. A WOMAN (20s, polite, blank) sits with hands folded in her lap.

WOMAN
Relocation due to stalker harassment. Duration, indefinite.

She smiles. Perfect. Hollow.

WOMAN (CONT'D)
I'm grateful to be here.

Akira nods.

Yumi moves behind the woman. Just for a beat. The woman's lips shift. Barely audible.

WOMAN (CONT'D)
(quiet)
Get out. They collect the dead here.

Akira's eyes flick to the nearest camera. Back. Posture steady.

The woman's smile resumes. Seamless.

INT. NOCTURNE LTD. - HALLWAY - NIGHT

Long corridor. White glow.

Akira walks alone. Her shadow splits on the tile.

Rei stands to the side, back to her, facing a panel. Phone pressed to his ear.

A saved voicemail. The speaker bleeds:

CHILD'S VOICE
Did I do good, Papa?

He sees her. Deletes it. Pockets the phone.

He turns. His jaw works once. Then sets.

REI
You're not cleared for that wing. Unauthorized access triggers an automatic compliance review.

AKIRA
Then why isn't it locked?

He says nothing. She moves past.

INT. NOCTURNE LTD. - REASSIGNMENT ROOM - NIGHT

White. Sterile. A standing mirror so clean it barely returns a reflection.

Yumi enters holding a thin black file. Stays standing.

YUMI
Effective immediately, you are Shiori Takada. Age, twenty-seven. Primary vulnerability. Abandonment anxiety. The algorithm assigns vulnerability profiles based on intake biometrics. It's impersonal by design.

She opens the file. Akira takes it. Inside: an ID card. Passport. Lease. Pristine. Official.

AKIRA
How does an algorithm know what will break me?

YUMI
It doesn't know. It predicts. Based on cortisol response and micro-expression mapping. Your answers to questions you didn't realize were diagnostic.

AKIRA
Which questions?

Yumi passes the last document. Their fingers brush.

Yumi's hand holds a half-second longer than protocol requires. Then pulls back.

INT. NOCTURNE LTD. - THE WHISPER ROOM - NIGHT

A small booth. Eggshell walls. No mirrors. The sense of being watched from inside your own skin.

Akira steps in. The door seals with a pneumatic hiss. Ceiling light dims.

A speaker embedded in the wall crackles.

First: Shin's voice. The recording crisp. Captured close range. Without his knowledge.

SHIN
You should learn to keep secrets...

Akira winces. Fingers curl.

The recording shifts. Her sister's voice. Younger. Pulled from somewhere Akira cannot place.

SISTER
Did you forget me?

A low-frequency hum begins. Deep. Vibrational. Her fingernails twitch.

Beneath the low frequency. Three notes. Slowed. Detuned. Mechanical.

Scratching at her scar. Harder now. Breath short. Breath short.

A third sound. Below language. A frequency that bypasses the ear and settles in the chest.

Her body tightens. Hands over her ears.

The frequency is not in the room. It is in the walls. In the floor. In her.

The tone deepens. Silence.

The door slides open. Akira is on the floor. Knees drawn up. Fingernails bloody from scratching the eggshell walls.

Yumi kneels beside her. Touches her shoulder. Akira flinches.

YUMI
It's over.

Akira's breath shudders. She cannot speak for several seconds.

AKIRA
How long?

YUMI
Seven minutes.

AKIRA
It felt like years.

Yumi helps her stand. Akira's legs give once. She catches herself.

They walk. Yumi's hand stays at Akira's elbow. Professional. Almost.

INT. NOCTURNE LTD. - TRANSITION CHAMBER - NIGHT

A narrow room of obsidian black. Surfaces that could be walls or reflections. Impossible to tell.

The floor vibrates faintly beneath Akira's feet. Machinery below.

Yumi stands across from her. Without file or clipboard. Only herself.

YUMI
Final clearance protocol requires sustained silence. Thirty seconds.

AKIRA
I thought I passed.

YUMI
Compliance is a behavioral performance. Surrender requires neurological capitulation.

Akira meets her gaze. Her hands open and close at her sides.

YUMI (CONT'D)
Step forward.

Akira does. The vibration deepens.

YUMI (CONT'D)
Name?

AKIRA
Akira Kawasaki.

YUMI
No. Name?

AKIRA
Shiori Takada.

YUMI
Purpose?

AKIRA
To be forgotten.

The vibration stops. In the silence, her heartbeat. A flutter. Then stillness.

Yumi closes the distance. Touches Akira's forehead with two fingers.

Her hand trembles.

INT. NOCTURNE LTD. - SURVEILLANCE ROOM - NIGHT

Dim glow. Banks of screens. Yumi's voice, filtered through playback, fills the small room.

YUMI (O.S.)
Subject intake nominal. Emotional baseline stable. Physiological response within projected parameters. Anomalous compliance rate. Flag for review.

Rei sits alone in the blue light. Pen tapping the desk. The playback ends.

He rewinds. Listens to the last sentence again.

His pen stills.

Staring at the dark screen where Akira's intake scan was displayed. The reading Yumi dismissed.

He leaves the file. Turns off the screen.

The room goes dark.

INT. NOCTURNE LTD. - AKIRA'S ASSIGNED APARTMENT - NIGHT

Spartan. Too clean.

Generic touches applied like paint. Silk scarf, pink toothbrush, a digital frame.

It cycles photographs of strangers.

Akira sits on the bed. Still clothed. The ID card in her hand. SHIORI TAKADA in flawless Helvetica.

Her thumb runs across it. Again. And again.

In the hallway outside, Yumi stands at the door. Listening.

Her fingers twitch once. Then close.

She walks away.

INT. NOCTURNE LTD. - SURVEILLANCE ROOM - NIGHT

Dim blue glow. Monitors hum.

Rei alone. Back stiff. Eyes locked on one screen.

Akira sleeps on the feed. Curled on her side, ID card clutched in her hand.

Rei scrubs back the footage. Frame by frame.

A flicker. Behind her, a shadow. No shape should be there.

He freezes the frame. Enhances. Grain explodes across the screen.

Nothing.

Except her reflection in the dark glass behind the bed.

The angle is wrong. It faces the camera when she faces the wall.

REI
(low)
No timestamp anomaly. No entry log.

He encrypts the file. Labels it: CAT R-01 / Echo.

INT. NOCTURNE LTD. - REI'S PRIVATE OFFICE - NIGHT

A smaller room. Personal. Desk with a photograph turned face-down.

A coffee ring on the desk. Dried. Days old.

Three pens arranged parallel. A habit of precision that extends to everything except his shirt.

The filing cabinet. Steel, dented at the lower corner. The lock is new. The cabinet is not.

On the wall, a framed scroll — calligraphy, hand-brushed, glass-fronted. Old.

The ink has faded but the strokes remain. A hand that wrote this character ten thousand times.

The glass catches Rei's reflection. For a moment, he and the calligraphy occupy the same frame.

Files marked with cycle numbers fill the cabinet behind him.

Rei sits. Shirt stain he hasn't noticed. Tired.

A SPEAKER crackles on the desk.

VOICE (O.S.)
The new intake. Tell me.

REI
Processed. Standard deviation within acceptable institutional parameters. No action required.

VOICE
The readings.

REI
Elevated. But well within containable thresholds for a subject at this intake stage.

Silence on the line. Long.

VOICE
You have seen the waveform.

REI
I've reviewed waveforms across six cycles. This reads within parameters.

VOICE
Nothing like this one. Nothing since your father's rotation.

Rei's hand finds the edge of the desk. Holds.

REI
That comparison is premature. And above your clearance.

VOICE
Is it.

The speaker hisses. Static. Then:

VOICE (CONT'D)
The cycle requires stewards, Mikami. The building remembers even when the stewards forget.

The line goes dead.

Rei stares at the face-down photograph. Leaves it.

He opens the file cabinet. Bottom drawer. A folder dated decades ago.

Inside, a photograph. A young woman who could be Akira. Dark hair. Same jawline. Same posture.

Dated long before Akira's birth.

Beneath the photograph, a journal. Leather-bound. The spine cracked from use.

He closes the file. Locks the cabinet. Standing, the mask returns.

His father's handwriting. Small, obsessive, the penmanship of a man who recorded everything.

A notation dated decades ago. Clinical observations of a woman with readings that match the ones Yumi just flagged.

One word underlined three times in the margin.

His father pressed so hard the ink bled through to the next page.

Completion.

Rei touches the indentation where his father's pen broke the paper. His thumb fits the groove exactly.

On the wall, the scroll: □□. Hand-brushed. Centuries old.

The ink has bled into the paper so deeply it looks like a wound.

INT. NOCTURNE LTD. - DIAGNOSTIC LAB - NIGHT

Banks of data streams. Pulse charts. Mind scans in shifting waves.

The lab hums. Lights too white.

Yumi stands alone. Scrolling through Akira's neural feedback.

Two files overlay. Current session and archival. Beneath the noise, something too ordered. An emergent symmetry.

YUMI
(quiet)
That configuration should not exist within the current system parameters.

She isolates the waveform. The monitor glitches. Resolves.

A pattern. Recursive. Self-generating.

A TECHNICIAN (20s) enters. Freezes when he sees the screen.

TECHNICIAN
That's embedded? That's not supposed to —

YUMI
The waveform isn't a response. It's an origin point. Generating from inside her brain.

TECHNICIAN
No metadata. Clean.

YUMI
I've seen this before.
(beat)
It didn't survive.

TECHNICIAN
Should I report this to Tier One?

Yumi turns. Expression unreadable.

YUMI
That’s a system artifact. Residual noise from the prior calibration cycle.

Her hands are still on the keyboard. They have not stopped moving.

TECHNICIAN
What if it's not?

YUMI
Then the model is incomplete.

The terminal goes dark under her hand.

INT. NOCTURNE LTD. - AKIRA'S ROOM - NIGHT

Dark. Streetlight through blinds.

Her eyes open.

A faint buzz in the walls — or something behind them.

Sitting up, she sees it on her nightstand. Small. Burnt at the edges.

The jade cicada. Or its replica.

The sensation persists in her memory. Specific. The cool of jade against the life line of her palm.

She opens her hand. The skin is warm in the exact shape of the cicada.

Reaching for it, her fingers close on air.

The nightstand is empty.

Breath catches. The digital frame on the wall cycles. The faces shift position. They seem to turn toward her.

A sound through the walls. That same low frequency from the Whisper Room.

Her hand against the scar beneath her shirt.

INT. NOCTURNE LTD. - AKIRA'S BATHROOM - CONTINUOUS

Light on.

Mirror. Her reflection stares back. Delayed. Out of sync by a half-second.

The reflection blinks.

Akira has not.

The glass cracks. A single fissure from corner to corner.

INT. NOCTURNE LTD. - MAINTENANCE CORRIDOR - NIGHT

Harsh overhead lights. Metal underfoot.

Yumi and Rei face each other.

YUMI
You accessed her surveillance footage without authorization.

REI
The system flagged her independently. That has not occurred since the original protocols.

YUMI
She's carrying something. Or something's carrying her.

Rei checks the security feed. Akira's room — dark again. Still.

REI
Terminate the transfer sequence. Seal the corridor.

YUMI
No. We observe.

REI
On what basis? The classification framework requires documented evidence, not speculation.

YUMI
She’s already accessing the architecture. Without instruction.

REI
Specify. The diagnostic committee requires precise terminology in all clinical assessments.

Silence.

The lights stutter. A rhythmic pulse builds in the corridor walls. Then stops.

INT. NOCTURNE LTD. - CONTAINMENT BAY - NIGHT

Dimly lit. Humming machinery. Red indicator lights pulse. Slower. Slower.

A corrupted feed plays on Rei's monitor. Skips. Stutters.

The image: Akira in her room. Eyes on the camera. Pupils flooding dark — then static.

Rei watches. Plays the clip again. Same glitch. Same stare.

Yumi stands behind him. Her reflection faint in the monitor glass.

YUMI
You've played it seven times.

REI
That architecture was decommissioned. It should not exist in the current substrate.

YUMI
None of this is.

Stepping beside him, she locks her gaze to the broken feed.

YUMI (CONT'D)
She's the breach.

REI
We screened her. We wrote her.

YUMI
You can't edit what you don't understand.

Rei turns. Voice low.

REI
Then what is she, precisely? Give me the clinical designation.

Yumi's jaw tightens.

YUMI
I've read the older files. Before your time. Before mine.

REI
Archive noise. Residue from operational cycles we formally closed decades ago.

YUMI
Or a pattern.

Turning toward the hallway, she walks.

YUMI (CONT'D)
Prep Chamber Three for isolated observation. No assistants. No recording override.

REI
You're going in alone. No observation personnel. My authorization.

YUMI
I need to see what's left.

She exits. The monitor loops. Akira's eyes, that stare, static.

INT. NOCTURNE LTD. - INTERVIEW CHAMBER - NIGHT

Sealed. Windowless. A single bulb above a sterile steel table. Two chairs.

Yumi enters alone. Closes the door behind her.

Akira sits on the far side. Already seated. Still. Awake.

YUMI
Your biometrics indicate zero sleep in the past thirty-one hours.

AKIRA
I wasn't invited to.

Yumi sits. Places a black folder on the table. Leaves it shut.

YUMI
Do you know why you're here?

AKIRA
Because I stared too long.

Yumi's mouth twitches.

YUMI
The readings suggest you aren't the only one looking.

The bulb burns overhead.

AKIRA
What is this place?

YUMI
You already know.

AKIRA
Or a cage?

YUMI
Only if you remember the outside.

They hold each other's gaze.

AKIRA
I saw it. In the mirror.

YUMI
What did you see?

AKIRA
Not me. Not her. But something waiting to take shape.

Yumi leans forward. Voice drops.

YUMI
They used to say Kurokami wore a woman's face.

AKIRA
Do you think that's me?

YUMI
I think you're remembering what we erased.

Akira's mouth curves. Teeth behind glass.

AKIRA
Then you should've done a better job.

INT. NOCTURNE LTD. - OBSERVATION CORRIDOR - NIGHT

Security glass stretches the length of the hall. Behind it: identical rooms, sealed and silent.

Rei leans against the glass. Unlit cigarette between his fingers. Thumb on the lighter. Lets it die.

Yumi steps closer from behind.

YUMI
You still think she's breaking down?

REI
No.

YUMI
Then what?

REI
She’s breaching the substrate.
Without external input.

Joining him at the glass, their reflections float above the live feed. Akira on her bed. Still. Alert.

YUMI
She recognized the surveillance.
Didn't pretend she didn't.

REI
Every subject glitches. Dream spill, bleed-through. That's protocol.

YUMI
(quiet)
She saw me.

Rei turns.

REI
She doesn't know who you were. Give it time.

Yumi says nothing.

Her hand touches the glass. Not Akira's cell. The one beside it. Empty. The interior charred black.

YUMI
No one's ever lasted past Phase Three.

REI
She hasn’t. The readings confirm baseline compliance.

A beat. Rei pockets the lighter.

INT. NOCTURNE LTD. - AKIRA'S ROOM - NIGHT

Akira sits cross-legged on the floor. Beside her — a photograph.

Two girls. Her and someone she once knew. Burned at the edges. She has no memory of it.

A knock. Silence.

The door opens. Yumi steps in. No file. No clipboard.

AKIRA
What do you want?

YUMI
You said it wasn't you. In the mirror.

AKIRA
It smiled.

YUMI
Then who was it?

Akira stands. Slow.

AKIRA
Someone I'll have to become.

Yumi crosses the room. They stand face to face.

YUMI
When I went through... I thought I was still me. Until I laughed and it didn't sound like mine.

AKIRA
Is this your laugh now?

Leaning forward, Yumi's hand rises. Finds the crook of Akira's arm.

The exact spot where the intake needle went in. Holds it without looking.

YUMI
I don't laugh anymore.

AKIRA
Then let's remember how.

The lights dim.

INT. NOCTURNE LTD. - TRANSFER CHAMBER - NIGHT

Circular. Velvet-black soundproofing. Cameras hidden behind mirrored domes.

Akira stands alone in the center. Transfer whites, sleeveless. Her scar exposed.

A circular track of light ignites beneath her feet.

A speaker crackles overhead.

A door hiss-opens. Yumi enters. She carries a polished metal briefcase.

AKIRA
Another gift?

YUMI
A final confirmation.

The case opens. Inside: a syringe. Black fluid, viscous. It shifts inside the glass, responding to warmth.

AKIRA
No.

YUMI
You agreed. Full conversion.

AKIRA
I didn't understand the terms.

Stepping closer, Yumi holds the syringe with both hands.

YUMI
You disappear so you may be remade.

AKIRA
And what do I become?

YUMI
Someone we can trust.

AKIRA
Then you made a mistake.

Akira knocks the case aside. The syringe shatters. Black liquid hisses against the floor — smoke where it burns.

No alarms. The system holds.

YUMI
Do you think this isn't part of the script?

AKIRA
Then rewrite it.

Turning, Akira walks toward the sealed door. It does not open.

She presses her hand against it. Waits.

Her reflection appears in the mirrored dome above. The glass warps — dark, convex, alive.

Yumi sees it. Her face drains.

Akira is gone.

The burned symbol etched faintly into the floor where the fluid fell.

Kneeling, Yumi touches the ash.

INT. NOCTURNE LTD. - TRANSFER OBSERVATION ROOM - NIGHT

Sterile. Circular. No corners.

Yumi stands behind a two-way mirror.

On the other side, Akira kneels on the floor. Eyes closed. Palms flat to the tile.

AKIRA
It's quieter when you're here.

Yumi holds.

AKIRA (CONT'D)
Just less screaming.

Yumi steps into the room. The door closes behind her.

YUMI
You shouldn't be unsupervised.

AKIRA
I'm always supervised. Just not always seen.

Yumi lowers herself across from her. Their knees nearly touch.

YUMI
What do you think this place is?

AKIRA
A mirror.

YUMI
Of what?

AKIRA
What you want me to be.

Reaching forward, Akira's fingertips almost brush Yumi's.

AKIRA (CONT'D)
You knew my sister.

YUMI
That's not —

AKIRA
Did you erase her... or did you love her first?

The question lands like a blade between them.

Yumi's hands still on the monitoring console. Her vitals spike on the readout she is pretending not to watch.

Through the glass, the observation room stretches behind Akira. The equipment forgotten.

Yumi's hand trembles. She covers it with the other.

YUMI
No memory.

AKIRA
Liar.

YUMI
You were never supposed to wake up like this.

AKIRA
Then close your eyes.

Yumi leans forward. Eyes fixed.

She holds back. Standing, her voice goes clinical.

YUMI
Standard protocol resumes at 0600.
Full neurological diagnostics.

Turning to leave, she reaches the door.

AKIRA
You felt her die.

Yumi stops. Back to her.

AKIRA (CONT'D)
I think that's why you keep
watching me.

The door hisses open.

Yumi exits.

Akira lowers her head. The hum stops.

INT. NOCTURNE LTD. - LAUNDRY CORRIDOR - NIGHT

Steam lingers. White sheets ripple on suspended wires — institutional, bloodless.

Akira walks the corridor. Arms cradling herself.

At the far end, a silhouette. Small. Slight. Back turned.

Stepping forward, Akira reaches.

The silhouette resolves into another subject, folding laundry in silence.

Her hand drops. She stands there a moment longer than she should.

INT. NOCTURNE LTD. - DINING HALL - NIGHT

Identical robes. Plastic trays. Robotic efficiency.

Akira sits at the edge. Far from the others.

Across the room, a group of subjects freeze mid-bite.

One of them — older, eyes sunken — stands slowly.

SUBJECT
(quiet)
Kurokami...

The others shush him. He sits. Trembling.

Akira stays still.

INT. NOCTURNE LTD. - ARCHIVE NOOK - NIGHT

A tucked-away cubicle of forgotten files. Strip lighting buzzes above dusty shelves.

Akira enters.

A SUBJECT (19, androgynous, gaunt) kneels on the floor. Restocking boxes.

SUBJECT (19)
(low)
This is restricted.

AKIRA
Then why are you here?

No answer. Akira crosses to a folder marked: TERMINATION - SUBJECT CLASS D - UNRESOLVED.

SUBJECT (19)
You shouldn't touch that.

She opens it. Redacted text. A name that is not hers but feels like it.

Her hand holds the page.

SUBJECT (19) (CONT'D)
You're not supposed to be here yet.

AKIRA
But I am.

The Subject flinches. A camera above them whirs.

Akira flips deeper. A second folder: SUBJECT 47 — STATUS: ACTIVE / SUBLEVEL.

Memorizing the location. The file returned to its place.

SUBJECT (19)
They'll come now.

AKIRA
Let them.

Walking out. Unhurried. The camera follows.

INT. NOCTURNE LTD. - SUBLEVEL WARD - NIGHT

The corridor gets older as she descends. Newer tile to concrete to stone. Fluorescent to incandescent to bare bulb.

A ward. Three beds. Two empty. One occupied.

SUBJECT 47. Woman, 30s but looks older. Shaved head growing back in patches.

She sits cross-legged, folding the same piece of paper over and over.

SUBJECT 47
What day is it?

AKIRA
I don't know.

SUBJECT 47
Neither do I.

Akira sits on the opposite bed. Waits.

47's voice comes in fragments. Staccato. Urgent. Words rationed like water.

SUBJECT 47 (CONT'D)
A compound.

She taps her temple.

SUBJECT 47 (CONT'D)
Targets the hippocampus.

AKIRA
What compound?

SUBJECT 47
First the names. Then the faces.

Her hand flattens against the paper.

SUBJECT 47 (CONT'D)
Then the feeling of having had a face.

SUBJECT 47 (CONT'D)
You forget in layers.

Her hands never stop folding.

SUBJECT 47 (CONT'D)
Write the reports. Go home.

AKIRA
How do you still know this?

SUBJECT 47
Because I was staff. Before I was this.

Akira goes still.

AKIRA
Staff.

SUBJECT 47
You give the injections.

She smooths the fold. Presses it flat.

SUBJECT 47 (CONT'D)
Then you're in a gown. No memory of putting it on.

AKIRA
The cycle.

SUBJECT 47
Rotates. Subject. Staff. Subject. Until you're used up.

AKIRA
What happens to the ones who remember?

47 holds up the paper. □□. Folded from memory. Over and over.

SUBJECT 47
You're not the first mistake.

AKIRA
How many before me?

Silence. Her eyes drift to the bare bulb above. She squints against the light.

SUBJECT 47
Is it raining outside?

AKIRA
I don't know.

SUBJECT 47
I liked rain.

Akira stands. Her hand finds the doorframe.

INT. NOCTURNE LTD. - COURTYARD GARDEN - NIGHT

A door opens onto a small courtyard. Open sky. Stars. Plants growing.

A structural gap where an older building's roof collapsed decades ago. Rubble cleared, soil accumulated. An accident of architecture.

An ELDERLY SUBJECT tends the plants.

She has been here so long she is part of the landscape — not the metaphor.

The literal earth under her fingernails.

ELDERLY SUBJECT
The jasmine blooms at midnight. I never knew that before I came here.

Akira stands at the threshold. The old woman keeps her hands in the soil.

ELDERLY SUBJECT (CONT'D)
Sit. The ground is warm from the pipes underneath.

Akira sits. Tea from a thermos. Steam rises between them.

ELDERLY SUBJECT (CONT'D)
The ones who fight the hardest always break the fastest. The secret isn't fighting. It's remembering what's worth keeping.

AKIRA
What do you keep?

ELDERLY SUBJECT
The jasmine. The stars. The sound of my daughter's voice saying my name.

Pouring the tea with both hands, she holds the cup until Akira takes it.

ELDERLY SUBJECT (CONT'D)
They took the name but not the sound.

A PA crackles somewhere inside. Lights shift in the corridor behind them.

The old woman registers it without fear. Resignation worn smooth by years.

ELDERLY SUBJECT (CONT'D)
You should go.

Akira stands. Looks back once. The old woman hums. A melody, low, almost familiar.

Akira descends. Uncertain she can find this place again.

INT. NOCTURNE LTD. - PSYCHOLOGICAL OBSERVATION CHAMBER - NIGHT

Clinical white. Table, two chairs, sensor wand. A one-way mirror.

Yumi stands by the table. Composed.

Akira enters. No shoes. Robe damp against her skin.

YUMI
Please be seated. The session begins when the indicator activates.

Akira stays standing.

AKIRA
Will I be shocked if I lie?

YUMI
Please be seated. The session begins when the indicator activates.

She sits. The wand hums as Yumi passes it over her — neck and wrists.

AKIRA
Why don't you ever ask me real questions?

YUMI
This evaluation measures involuntary response, not verbal content.

AKIRA
Then what is it about?

YUMI
Control.

Akira leans forward.

AKIRA
Yours or mine?

Yumi holds her gaze.

Akira places her palms on the table. Spreads her fingers.

AKIRA (CONT'D)
If I'm just a subject, why are your hands shaking?

Yumi's hand curls into a fist.

Rising, Akira steps behind Yumi. Close. Her breath against Yumi's neck.

AKIRA (CONT'D)
Tell me what you did with her.

Yumi stiffens.

AKIRA (CONT'D)
You remember her. I see it in your skin.

Yumi turns. Sudden. Inches apart.

YUMI
You don't get to ask me questions.

AKIRA
You already answered. Your hands told me.

Reaching for Akira's wrist, Yumi presses too hard.

Her thumb finds the pulse point and holds. Like she has done this before without knowing it.

YUMI
Power?

AKIRA
No. This is surrender.

Yumi's eyes go wide. Breath fast against Akira's mouth.

She kisses her.

Too hard. Too honest.

Pulling away, breath ragged, Yumi's gaze catches the mirror.

YUMI
Terminate sequence.

Nothing happens.

The door opens. Rei stands there. Watching.

He saw everything.

Akira turns. Composed.

Yumi stares at the floor.

REI
Yumi. With me.

Yumi follows. Hands still shaking.

Akira remains. Alone.

The sensors fade. The only sound left is her breathing.

INT. NOCTURNE LTD. - CORRIDOR OUTSIDE OBSERVATION - NIGHT

Rei walks. Yumi follows.

REI
That was a direct violation of containment protocol.

Yumi says nothing.

REI (CONT'D)
You still don't know what she is.

YUMI
(beat)
Yes.

Rei stops. Turns.

REI
Then conduct yourself accordingly. This institution has protocols for a reason.

INT. NOCTURNE LTD. - FILE ARCHIVE - NIGHT

Cold aisles. Locked cabinets. Metal drawers labeled in kanji and barcode.

Dying fluorescents. No cameras. A dead zone in the surveillance grid.

Akira enters. Hospital robe damp against her back.

Her fingernails ragged from the Whisper Room walls.

Moving through the rows. Steady. Unhurried. But her breath gives her away — shallow, too controlled.

She stops at a terminal. The screen glows.

AUTHENTICATION FAILED. CLEARANCE REQUIRED.

A visual stutter. A loop glitch. She touches a key.

The screen wavers. A file list — names partially redacted.

One entry: SUBJECT 0-KK.

A photograph blooms on the screen. Two girls. Young. Identical eyes. One slightly older. One bruised.

Data fractures. The screen pixelates. Before it collapses — □□. Then black.

She moves to the cabinets. And pulls drawers.

Inside: files organized by subject number. Beside each, a cycle count. Some subjects have two entries. Some have four.

Each entry holds a different identity card. A different name. A different assignment.

The final entry in every file: a single red stamp. TERMINATED — HONOURED.

Her fingers stop on one cabinet. Subject 33 — her number.

Two prior entries she has never seen. Names that are not hers. Faces that are.

Then the deeper drawer.

Clinical notes. Handwritten. Precise, practiced, cold.

Her handwriting.

Akira's hand curls against the metal.

The notes are about other subjects. Observations. Assessments. Dosage recommendations. Dated years before her intake.

Signed with a name she has never used. But the hand is unmistakable.

Page after page. Her own words recommending corrections.

About someone who could have been Subject 47.

One file lies open beneath the rest. A photograph clipped to the corner.

A woman. Mid-thirties. Eyes that refuse the camera.

The recommendation is one line, in her hand. Resistant. Lucid. Correction advised.

A name in the margin, underlined twice. Haruko. Subject 29.

The room tilts. She drops the file.

Papers scatter across the cold floor. Her hands shake — violent, uncontrollable.

INT. NOCTURNE LTD. - FILE ARCHIVE - CONTINUOUS

Akira on the floor. Clinical notes scattered around her.

She cries. Hyperventilation, snot, the sounds that come when every story collapses.

She curls in. Knees to chest. Pounds the cabinet with her fist. The metal rings. Again.

Her palm splits on a drawer edge. Blood smears across a page of her own handwriting.

Rocking. Arms wrapped tight around herself.

AKIRA
(barely audible)
I didn't. I didn't.

She presses her forehead to the floor. Concrete against skin. Cold.

Her throat raw. Mucus on her lip.

She wipes it with the back of her hand. The hand comes away bloody.

The archive hums around her. Overhead lights catch and hold.

She lies there. Chest heaving. Then slowing.

The sobbing becomes ragged exhales. Shuddering breaths that space further apart.

Then stillness. Breath by breath. Each one chosen.

She rolls onto her side. Stares at the scattered pages. Her handwriting. The precision. The compliance.

Slowly, she stops.

Lifts her head. Picks up one page.

Studies the clinical language. The practiced detachment. The efficient recommendations.

Her jaw sets.

She stands. Knees unsteady. Blood from her palm dripping on the tile.

And gathers the pages. Folds them carefully. Tucks them inside her robe.

When she walks out, her face is different. Harder.

INT. NOCTURNE LTD. - MEMORY INDEX - NIGHT

Rows of obsolete terminals hum. The air is wet. Decay in digital form.

Akira walks between the aisles. Eyes swollen. Hands bloodied.

One monitor wakes without touch.

Her face on the screen — younger, paler.

Data scrolls: SUBJECT 0-KK / □□ / KUROKAMI.

She reaches toward the screen. The image glitches.

Footsteps behind her.

She kills the screen. Ducks behind the console.

Through a gap in the hardware — a figure enters.

The WOMAN from the common room. Frail. Silent. Eyes gone glassy.

The woman walks to the screen. Touches it. Akira's face flashes again.

The woman tilts her head. Slow, deliberate. A scar on her neck, the same place Akira has one.

WOMAN
(quiet)
I know the shape of your silence.

A second monitor flickers. Holographic fog spills from a projector behind the console.

Akira rises.

A memory forming in the mist. A younger Akira at the threshold of Nocturne. Smiling. Willing.

A voice from the playback. Her own.

AKIRA (MEMORY)
I want to be clean.

The projected Akira signs a document. The system stamps it.

Consent logged.

Real Akira watches her own smile. A face she does not recognize wearing an expression she cannot forgive.

AKIRA (CONT'D)
Do you know me?

The woman turns. Her eyes twitch. Listening to something beyond Akira's range.

WOMAN
They can't kill you yet.

Behind her, the screen blinks — SYSTEM ALERT: PRESENCE BREACH.

The room's lights shift red.

WOMAN (CONT'D)
Run.

Akira runs.

INT. NOCTURNE LTD. - VAULTED COUNCIL ROOM - NIGHT

Circular. No windows. Obsidian walls catch no light.

Three elevated chairs above them. Ceremonial. Unused.

Rei stands in the center. Pressed suit. Hands behind his back.

The door seals behind Yumi.

REI
Sit down, please. This is a formal review.

She stays standing.

REI (CONT'D)
Immediately. The session has started.

Yumi sits. The chair faces a bank of mirrors.

The glass flickers to life. Surveillance feeds, slightly out of sync.

On one feed: Yumi kneeling before Akira in the observation chamber. Breath too fast. The kiss.

On a second feed: same room. Same timestamp. Yumi alone. Talking to an empty chair.

Ninety-three minutes of conversation with no one.

REI (CONT'D)
Explain to me, for the official record, which version is authentic.

Yumi stares at both versions of herself.

YUMI
Both.

REI
That is the wrong answer.

He circles behind her. Close enough to feel the heat off his skin.

REI (CONT'D)
You're suspended. No contact with Subject 33. No access to her floor.

YUMI
On whose authority?

REI
Mine. Per institutional authority.

His thumb flicks the lighter. The unlit cigarette between his fingers.

REI (CONT'D)
You kissed a subject. On institutional surveillance. During a formal observation session.

YUMI
She's Kurokami.

Rei's lighter stills.

YUMI (CONT'D)
The ones who remembered. Before we learned to prevent it.

REI
Institutional folklore. Staff mythology for readings they cannot explain.

YUMI
Data. Recursive memory in every confirmed case. Erasure accelerates the cycle.

REI
Proof is not the point. Compliance is.

He lifts something from his pocket. Small. Silver.

REI (CONT'D)
Good girl.

A SCALPEL catches the overhead light.

YUMI
(low)
Are you going to cut me?

REI
Only if you keep bleeding into the work.

He places the scalpel in her hand. The blade rests against her palm.

REI (CONT'D)
I have a daughter. She attends school in the Minato district.

(beat)

REI (CONT'D)
She doesn't know what I do here.

His jaw works once. Then sets.

REI (CONT'D)
That's the only thing I've done right.

YUMI
Why stay?

REI
Older than the building. Older than the family.

His jaw works. The institutional mask slipping for the first time.

REI (CONT'D)
My father died in the recovery ward. Third sublevel. Staff found him at his desk. He was writing a correction report.

(beat)

REI (CONT'D)
The subject survived. My father did not.

He picks up the scalpel. Turns it in the light. Sets it down.

REI (CONT'D)
That is what devotion looks like.

He steps back. The feeds loop behind him. Yumi kissing Akira, Yumi talking to nothing.

REI (CONT'D)
Choose your loyalty. Or we'll choose for you.

Yumi stands. The scalpel still in her hand.

She walks out.

INT. NOCTURNE LTD. - YUMI'S QUARTERS - NIGHT

Small. Personal. The room of someone who stopped decorating years ago.

Yumi sits at a terminal. Lab coat gone. Bare arms.

Without the institutional armor she looks younger. Smaller.

Her hands hang at her sides. The hands that calibrated the compound, held the needle.

The hands that documented twelve years of corrections in handwriting the system never questioned.

The scalpel from Rei on the desk beside her. Untouched.

She runs Akira's readings against her pharmacological model.

ON SCREEN: a clinical framework. Chemical structures. Decay curves.

The compound causes spatial memory artifacts. Proprioceptive dissonance. Somatic hallucination.

Documented. Measurable. Treatable.

Scrolling through environmental schematics.

The corridors bend without logic. Asymmetric floor plans, low-frequency hum in the walls.

Humidity calibrated to trigger emotional states. Lighting cycles matched to circadian disruption protocols.

Everything Akira is experiencing has a pharmaceutical explanation.

One clean model. The data aligns. The pharmacology, the mirror, the frequency. All of it.

Yumi leans back. Exhales.

Her eyes move across the room. The environmental controls on her wall. The calibration charts she pinned there.

The compound formulas in her handwriting.

All of it hers.

She closes the model. Opens archived surveillance.

An audio fragment loads before the video. A voice from an old session. A subject she once monitored.

FEMALE SUBJECT
You didn't stop it. You watched.

Then the footage.

Akira, walking a corridor. Hospital robe. Feet bare on the tile.

The date stamp reads: THREE YEARS AGO.

Yumi's hand freezes on the mouse.

The model cannot explain that.

She watches. The three-years-ago Akira moves with her gait. Her posture.

Left hand opening and closing. Her tic.

Yumi replays it. Pauses on Akira's face.

She opens her desk drawer. Inside: her master keycard. Beside it, a single-dose syringe. Blue-tinted.

She touches both.

Closes the drawer.

INT. NOCTURNE LTD. - INTERROGATION SUITE - DAY

Sterile. Seamless. White that erases depth.

Akira sits at a metal table. Her stillness has changed — heavier, informed.

Yumi enters carrying a black leather folder.

YUMI
The preliminary assessment requires approximately twelve minutes.

Akira watches her.

AKIRA
Whose handwriting is in the older files?

Yumi pauses. Then sits. Opens the folder.

Slides a single page across the table.

Thick, high-gauge paper. Governmental. Beneath redacted blocks: SIGNATURE: KUROKAMI, AKIRA.

YUMI
You signed this the night of your intake.

AKIRA
No. I didn't.

YUMI
It's your name.

AKIRA
That's not the same thing.

Akira touches the edge of the paper.

AKIRA (CONT'D)
We don't forge consent. Isn't that what you told me?

YUMI
We record it.

AKIRA
No. You perform it.

YUMI
You were lucid. Articulate.

AKIRA
I was staff.

Silence.

AKIRA (CONT'D)
I processed people. I recommended corrections.

Yumi's composure fractures. A flinch she fails to hide.

AKIRA (CONT'D)
You already knew.

YUMI
I suspected. Since your temporal readings came back.

AKIRA
How long?

YUMI
Long enough.

Yumi stands. Gathers the file.

AKIRA
If I signed it, revoke it.

YUMI
You can't revoke what you don't remember giving.

Yumi exits.

Akira sits with the name on the page.

The name on the page flickers. For a single frame, it reads: NAMIKO.

INT. NOCTURNE LTD. - DORMITORY HALL - NIGHT

Muted. Institutional beige. Antiseptic and warm linen.

Akira moves through the corridor. Eyes swollen from the archive. Hands still bloodied.

A door stands open. Inside, a medical chair. An IV drip feeding clear fluid into a motionless arm.

She stops.

The subject in the chair. Nineteen. Androgynous. Gaunt.

The same face from the archive nook. The one who said they would come.

They came.

The correction sequence stalled when the grid died. The compound half-administered.

The subject suspended between who they were and who the system was making them.

On the floor beside the chair, a data chip.

Fallen from the subject's hand or planted beneath the seat. Small. Unlabeled.

Akira looks at the chip. Looks at the subject. The drip line still feeding.

She picks up the chip first.

Tucks it into her robe. Then reaches for the IV line.

Pulls it free. Blood beads at the crook of the subject's elbow.

The subject's eyes flutter. Unfocused. They see Akira but cannot place her.

She works the restraint buckle. The subject's wrist drops free. Then the other.

The subject stares at their own hands. Flexing fingers they are not sure belong to them.

AKIRA
(quiet)
Can you walk?

No answer. The subject stands. Unsteady. Reaches for the wall.

They look at Akira. The recognition comes slowly. Incomplete.

SUBJECT (19)
(barely audible)
You came back.

Akira says nothing. The chip against her ribs. The evidence she chose first.

The subject shuffles toward the corridor. Akira watches them go.

At a communal console near the dormitory entrance, she slips the chip into the input tray.

The screen flashes. UPLOADING... ERROR... DATA CORRUPT.

A glitch. Faces. A child's voice. NAMIKO.

The screen resets. Blank.

INT. NOCTURNE LTD. - BACK HALLWAY - NIGHT

Yumi stands alone. Watching security footage on a wall-mounted feed.

One feed: static. Another: Akira walking where she should not be.

Rei steps from the shadows behind her.

REI
You follow her. Every corridor. Every deviation.

Yumi turns.

REI (CONT'D)
Belief dressed as survival. Nothing more.

YUMI
Observation.

REI
Your clearance was formally revoked after the observation incident.

YUMI
The observation feeds are accessible to all senior-level personnel.

REI
Nothing within this facility falls under public jurisdiction or disclosure mandate.

He steps closer.

REI (CONT'D)
She's stolen something. She knew it would cost another subject.

Yumi's hands clench.

REI (CONT'D)
Ask yourself what that makes her, given the institutional classification framework.

He walks away.

INT. NOCTURNE LTD. - HIDDEN MONITORING STATION - NIGHT

Pipes drip. Condensation runs down concrete walls.

Akira squeezes through a gap between corroded ventilation ducts.

The passage opens into a forgotten room. Old CRT screens, most dark.

A control station abandoned when the building was renovated.

She touches a panel. One screen flickers to life.

Not footage. A system directory. Environmental control architecture.

The operational blueprint for the building's frequency generators, humidity calibration, circadian disruption protocols.

Yumi's work. Every override code, every frequency calibration, every behavioral trigger.

Her fingers move across the keyboard. Staff knowledge. Muscle memory she cannot explain.

She reads the architecture. Understands it before she finishes reading.

One subsystem flagged in red. ENVIRONMENTAL FREQUENCY MATRIX. Override accessible from any hub terminal on the maintenance level.

The tone that keeps subjects disoriented.

Beside it, a secondary frequency profile. Unlabeled. Three notes.

The melody from the courtyard garden. The one the elderly woman hummed.

The one buried somewhere in Akira's chest before the first correction.

She memorizes the override path. Kills the screen.

Pressing her palm against the cold monitor. Over the architectural map of the building that made her.

She knows what she is going to do.

INT. NOCTURNE LTD. - ENVIRONMENTAL CONTROL HUB - NIGHT

A maintenance level junction. Cable runs and conduit overhead. The air thick with machine heat.

A hub terminal built into the wall. Green cursor blinking. Operational since the renovation. Untouched since the last staff rotation.

Akira enters. Hands steady for the first time since the archive.

She types the override path from memory. The environmental frequency matrix loads.

Active systems scroll the screen. Correction frequency broadcasting on every floor. Humidity at 78%.

Lighting cycle set to 19-hour circadian disruption. The building tuned to keep its occupants lost.

Her fingers stop on the correction frequency.

She could shut it down. Kill the hum. Let the silence do the work.

Instead, she opens the secondary frequency profile. The three-note melody. Unlabeled in the system. Older than the protocols.

She routes it through the correction speakers. All of them.

OVERRIDE ACCEPTED.

The correction hum dies. Three notes fill the gap. Low. Rising. Spreading floor by floor.

Akira stands back from the terminal. Listens.

Somewhere above her, in the common room, a woman lifts her head.

Her lips move. Humming a melody she has not heard since before her correction.

In the dormitory, a man sits up in bed. Stares at the wall.

His mouth opens. He says a name. Not the one on his wristband.

In the dining hall, three subjects stop eating.

In the dining hall, three subjects stop eating. One touches another's hand. Says a name.

Three notes through every speaker in the building.

Akira walks out. Behind her, the terminal scrolls: ENVIRONMENTAL MATRIX OVERRIDE ACTIVE. REVERSION LOCKED.

She locked it. Staff knowledge. The override code her hands remembered before her mind caught up.

INT. NOCTURNE LTD. - SUBLEVEL CORRIDOR - NIGHT

Akira emerges from the maintenance passage. Kawasaki printout folded in her robe. Clinical notes against her skin.

Turning a corner.

Rei stands at the end of the corridor. Guards flank him. Three.

REI
You've accessed the environmental matrix. The frequency cascade is spreading to every floor.

AKIRA
What happened to Namiko?

REI
(beat)
Who told you that name? That designation is classified above your clearance level.

AKIRA
The building did.

Rei extends his hand.

REI
The subjects you just — you have no idea what you've done. Reverse the override. Now.

She reaches into her robe. Hands over the Kawasaki printout. The clinical notes — most of them.

Two pages palmed inside her waistband.

He examines the papers. His expression shifts at the handwriting.

REI (CONT'D)
Tell me precisely where you found these. Which archive, which terminal, which access point.

AKIRA
You already know.

He steps into her space. His hand closes around her wrist.

Twists her arm behind her back. Pins her against the wall.

His mouth at her ear.

REI
(low)
You're a subject within this facility. Nothing more. Remember that distinction.

She is genuinely afraid. Breath fast. Body rigid against the concrete.

A guard steps closer with restraints.

Her eyes scan the wall behind Rei. A seam in the panels.

Staff knowledge. From a cycle she cannot remember living.

Her free hand finds the latch. A maintenance hatch opens.

She drops. Slides through. The hatch locks behind her.

REI (CONT'D)
Find her. Seal the sublevel corridors. Mobilize the second unit.

Guards scatter.

Crawling through the maintenance shaft. Hands bleeding. Breath ragged.

Most of her evidence gone. Two pages of her own handwriting pressed against her ribs.

INT. NOCTURNE LTD. - HIDDEN MONITORING ALCOVE - NIGHT

A dead space between walls.

Akira stumbles in. Shaking. Blood on her palms. Breath hitching.

A terminal. Still active. The cascade left it running without oversight.

She touches the keyboard. The screen blinks awake.

Archived footage. Timestamped years ago.

A correction session.

A figure in a sterile procedural mask. Clinical. Anonymizing. White gloves.

Instruments laid out on a surgical tray with care.

The figure works over a restrained subject. Precise, practiced hands.

The masked figure speaks.

MASKED FIGURE
Breathe.

Akira's spine straightens.

The intonation. The cadence. The exact way Rei said it to her in the lobby. The night she arrived.

Practiced.

The subject's face becomes visible.

SUBJECT 47. Younger. Before the damage. Before the patches in her hair. Before the folded paper.

MASKED FIGURE (CONT'D)
Breathe. Stay with me.

(beat)

MASKED FIGURE (CONT'D)
You're doing well.

Gentle. Thorough. He speaks like a doctor. Like a man who believes he is healing.

He adjusts an instrument. His hand steady. His touch careful.

The subject cries. He wipes her face with a cloth. Continues.

Akira watches. Hands flat on the terminal desk.

She recognizes the voice. The posture. The way his left hand braces while his right applies pressure.

The footage continues. The figure removes the mask. Wipes sweat from his face.

Rei. Younger. Unburdened.

Akira plays the footage back. Pauses on the moment he says it.

MASKED FIGURE (CONT'D)
Breathe.

She closes the terminal. And sits in the dark.

The word hangs in the alcove.

She stands. Tucks the two pages deeper into her robe.

Her face in the dead monitor's glass — resolved. Armed.

She walks out.

INT. CORRECTION CHAMBER - NIGHT

White. Fluorescent. Surgical.

Akira on a steel table. Wrists locked in polymer restraints. Ankles bound.

A mask pressed over her nose and mouth. Connected to a drip line feeding from an IV stand.

Two technicians at the console. Lab coats. Latex gloves. Neither looks at her.

The needle is already in. Clear fluid moving through the tube. Slow. Measured.

The compound enters cold. She feels it climb her arm. A chill that maps the vein.

A technician adjusts the mask. His thumb brushes her cheekbone.

The overhead light splits through the mask's condensation. Prisms on her eyelashes.

Her teeth chatter. Not from cold. From the compound finding the first layer of what it was built to dissolve.

A memory surfaces and dies in the same breath. A girl's braid. Jade cool against her palm.

The sound of her own name in a voice she cannot place.

Gone. The compound dissolving it before she can hold on.

The tone from the Whisper Room

Akira's fingers curl against the restraints. Release. Curl again.

TECHNICIAN
Baseline stable. Beginning sequence.

The second technician adjusts a dial. The hum deepens.

Monitors scroll data. Heart rate. Cortisol levels.

Neural mapping in real time. Patterns shaped like weather systems. The brain making and unmaking itself.

The compound reaches her bloodstream. Her body goes rigid. Eyes roll white. The mask fogs.

Her hands stop fighting the restraints. She goes still. Deciding.

Through the mask, barely audible:

AKIRA
Namiko.

INT. NOCTURNE LTD. - CORRECTION CHAMBER - YEARS EARLIER

The same room. Cleaner. The instruments newer.

The steel table sits empty under a brighter light.

NAMIKO stands at the console. Akira's face. A staff badge. A lab coat.

She reads a file. Her own handwriting fills the page.

Dosage logs. Subject numbers. Corrections she signed.

Her hand shakes. The file goes down.

A MASKED FIGURE waits by the table. Sterile gown. Gloved hands.

MASKED FIGURE
You understand this is permanent.

NAMIKO
I'm counting on it.

MASKED FIGURE
You can walk out. Return to your post.

NAMIKO
And do it again tomorrow.

She holds his gaze. Steady.

NAMIKO (CONT'D)
No.

She removes the badge. Sets it on the console.

The lab coat next. Folded. Laid on the chair.

She lies on the table. Herself. By choice.

The MASKED FIGURE closes the first restraint. She lets it.

NAMIKO (CONT'D)
How much will I keep?

MASKED FIGURE
Your hands. Your habits. Nothing that hurts.

NAMIKO
Take the rest.

An ATTENDANT steps to the table. Gray at the temples.

Namiko's hand finds hers. A folded paper passes between them.

NAMIKO (CONT'D)
(low)
Hold this. Don't read it.

ATTENDANT
What is it?

NAMIKO
Give it back when I ask.

Her grip tightens once.

NAMIKO (CONT'D)
Even if I don't remember asking.

The ATTENDANT closes her fingers around it. Silent.

The needle finds the vein. Slow pressure.

Namiko's eyes stay open. Fixed on the ceiling.

MASKED FIGURE
Your name. For the record.

NAMIKO
Namiko.

MASKED FIGURE
And after?

NAMIKO
Whoever you need.

The black fluid enters. Her pupils widen.

The fingers uncurl. Whatever she carried, set down.

One tear tracks her temple. It stays.

NAMIKO (CONT'D)
(barely audible)
I want to be clean.

Her focus drifts. The ceiling blurs to white.

The hum settles into her chest. Then deeper.

The ATTENDANT steps back. The paper closed in her fist.

Namiko's face goes slack. Whoever she was, leaving by degrees.

INT. CORRECTION CHAMBER - NIGHT

That ceiling. That hum.

This time, something in her holds.

On the primary screen, the neural map ripples. Standard response.

The sequence should flatten these patterns. Smooth the ridges. Return the subject to baseline.

The ripple holds.

It deepens.

TECHNICIAN
That's— hold on. Run it again.

The second technician retypes the command. Same result.

The pattern is reorganizing around the compound. Writing itself back.

He stands. Steps back from the console.

TECHNICIAN (CONT'D)
Abort sequence.

Nothing happens. The console is locked out.

The primary screen stutters. Subject data begins scrolling. Name, intake number, biometrics. Faster.

Names cycling. Old subjects. Dead subjects. Names that haven't appeared in the system for decades.

The scroll stops.

SUBJECT: AKIRA = NAMIKO = SUBJECT 00

Then the glyph. □□.

Filling the primary display. Spreading to the secondaries. Every screen in the chamber. Pulsing.

Akira's eyes open. Clear. Fixed on the ceiling.

TECHNICIAN (CONT'D)
(quiet)
She's writing back.

The air changes. The correction frequency stutters. Finds the three-note melody and cannot escape it.

The compound still in her blood. She can feel it searching for something to dissolve. Finding nothing it recognizes.

Her hands are shaking. She presses them flat against the steel table until they stop.

The restraints crash open. Both wrists. Both ankles. The system releasing her.

Akira sits up. Pulls the mask from her face. Sets it on the table.

The drip line tears free. A bead of blood at the crook of her elbow.

She stands.

The first technician presses both hands over his mouth. The sound he makes is involuntary.

The second is still at the console. Staring at the screens.

His hands on the keyboard. Fingers stopped.

The comms panel sparks. Goes dark. Emergency lighting kicks on — amber, low.

Akira looks at the first technician.

AKIRA
What was in it?

TECHNICIAN
Standard neuro-suppressant. The same compound for —

AKIRA
What was in mine?

He can't answer.

She picks up the syringe from the instrument tray. Holds it to the amber light. Half-empty.

Studies the fluid. Sets it down.

Walks to the door.

The mag-lock is dead. The cascade killed it. She pushes the door open.

The corridor stretches both directions. Left leads up — main level, exits, Tokyo.

Right descends.

She knows what's down there. The way her hands knew the keyboard.

The way her stride knew the corridors before her mind caught up.

She turns right. Deeper. Into the building that made her.

INT. NOCTURNE LTD. - SUBLEVEL RECOVERY CELL - NIGHT

Amber emergency light. A door stands open. The lock died with the grid.

Akira passes. Stops.

Inside, a chair bolted to the floor. A woman strapped to it.

A drip line feeds her arm. The bag half-empty. The sequence stalled when the console died.

A technician's coat on the floor. He ran when the screens turned.

HARUKO. Subject 29. The face from the file. Older now. Awake.

Her eyes find Akira. Change. Hold.

HARUKO
I know your face.

Akira steps forward. Stops at the threshold.

HARUKO (CONT'D)
You were at the desk. Behind the glass.

Akira says nothing.

HARUKO (CONT'D)
You wrote me down. You signed the page.

Her voice climbs. Raw. The words come faster.

HARUKO (CONT'D)
I said no. I said no and you wrote compliant.

Akira's jaw tightens.

AKIRA
(quiet)
I don't remember.

HARUKO
I do. It's coming back. All of it.

She pulls at the straps. The chair holds.

HARUKO (CONT'D)
Twenty-nine. You made me twenty-nine.

Akira crosses to the chair. Reaches for the restraint buckle.

HARUKO (CONT'D)
Don't touch me.

Akira's hand stops.

HARUKO (CONT'D)
You don't get to be the one.

Down the corridor. Voices. Boots on concrete. The second unit, regrouping.

The way down is clear. The window closing.

Akira looks toward the descent. Then back at the chair.

She works the buckle.

Haruko thrashes against her hands.

HARUKO (CONT'D)
I said no.

The first strap gives. Then the second. The ankle last.

Akira pulls the line from Haruko's arm. Blood beads at the vein.

Haruko stands. Unsteady. Steps back toward the door.

At the threshold she stops. Jaw set. Eyes dry.

HARUKO (CONT'D)
I don't forgive you.

AKIRA
I know.

HARUKO
Don't follow me.

Haruko goes. Into the corridor. Toward the others.

Akira alone. The empty chair. The restraints swinging.

Boots, closer now. The clear path down — gone.

Blood on her hand. She wipes it on the robe.

She turns to the descent. Slower. Hunted now.

INT. SURVEILLANCE BAY - NIGHT

Sixteen monitors. Yumi at the central console.

Every feed shows the same glyph. Corridors, chambers, the garden — overwritten.

YUMI
(steady)
Not a subject.

The fluorescents die. Amber emergency lighting takes their place.

One screen cracks. A thin line running corner to corner.

Yumi reaches for comms. Static. She tries the secondary channel. Dead.

She stands. Walks toward the sublevel stairs.

INT. ARCHIVE BELOW / DATA CHAMBER - NIGHT

Stairs descend. The architecture changes with each flight.

Modern composite panels give way to poured concrete.

Poured concrete gives way to stone. Meiji-era masonry, hand-cut blocks fitted without mortar.

The walls weep condensation. Something behind them hums, deep and constant, older than the wiring.

Akira reaches the bottom. One hand on the stone. It's warm.

The chamber opens low and wide. Server racks line every wall — different generations pressed together.

Solid-state drives beside tower units from the nineties.

Reel-to-reel tape machines from decades before that, magnetic ribbon still turning.

All running. All feeding the same system.

A CRT terminal sits on a metal desk bolted to the stone floor. Green phosphor cursor blinking.

Akira sits. Pulls the two pages from inside her robe.

Her own handwriting. Clinical shorthand she recognizes but cannot remember writing.

Subject intake numbers. Dosage protocols. In the margin, a file path in the system's old notation.

Her fingers find the keys on their own. Knowledge the process should have taken.

She types the path.

The screen fills. A directory listing. Files dated 1987, 1991, 2003, 2009.

Decades of records. Hardware older than the staff.

She opens the oldest.

Kawasaki Group letterhead. Corporate correspondence.

A photograph embedded in the scan. Men in dark suits around a conference table.

Behind them, architectural drawings pinned to a wall. This building. Before it was Nocturne Ltd.

Meeting minutes. Budget line items.

One entry circled in red ink. The same handwriting on the pages in her robe.

"Subject Renewal Protocol — Ongoing."

1987. The program predates the equipment. Predates the technology they just used on her. Predates Rei.

Only the stone is old enough.

She hits print.

Somewhere behind the server racks, a dot-matrix printer shudders to life. Paper feeding through. Slow. Grinding.

While it prints, she returns to her own notes.

The handwriting changes partway through the second page. Faster, slanting hard right. Written under the compound's influence.

The last line on the second page is a name.

She traces the letters with her fingertip.

Someone from an older cycle. Another woman who found this archive and left a trail.

The printer stops. She tears the sheet free.

Folds it with the others. Evidence against her skin. Two pages from her prior life, one printout from 1987.

She powers down the terminal. The green cursor dies.

Climbing back toward the surface. The layers in reverse. Stone to concrete to composite.

Each thinner than the one below.

INT. SUBLEVEL CORRIDOR - NIGHT

Low ceiling. Pipes overhead. Emergency lighting — amber, steady.

Akira moves through the corridor. Evidence folded inside her robe. The cascade has killed the main grid.

The building runs on generators now.

A sound behind a maintenance grate. Breathing. Someone sitting in the dark.

ATTENDANT 058. A woman, sixty or older. Gray hair pinned back.

Staff uniform worn soft at the elbows. ID badge barely legible. 058.

She looks up at Akira. Recognition hits her face like weather.

ATTENDANT 058
Oh.

Akira stops.

ATTENDANT 058 (CONT'D)
I thought you might come through here. When the screens went dark.

AKIRA
You know these corridors?

ATTENDANT 058
I've cleaned them for thirty-one years.

Akira studies her. The woman is calm.

And this woman sits behind a maintenance grate like she's been waiting while the facility falls apart around her.

AKIRA
Why aren't you running?

ATTENDANT 058
Because I remember you.

The pipes groan. Steam venting somewhere above them.

ATTENDANT 058 (CONT'D)
The last time. Before the procedure. They brought you to the chamber with your arms bound behind your back.
(beat)

ATTENDANT 058 (CONT'D)
You were smiling.

Silence.

ATTENDANT 058 (CONT'D)
I asked myself for years what that smile meant. I decided you knew something they couldn't reach.

AKIRA
What happened after?

ATTENDANT 058
Three days in the chamber. When you came out, you didn't know my name. You didn't know your own.
(beat)

ATTENDANT 058 (CONT'D)
But you walked the same way. Held your hands the same way. Your chopsticks at the table. Everything they said they'd erased — your body kept it.

Akira lowers herself to the floor. Sits across from the attendant. Eye level.

AKIRA
Was I fixed?

Attendant 058's mouth opens. Closes. She looks at the floor.

ATTENDANT 058
They said you were.

AKIRA
But.

ATTENDANT 058
Three weeks later, the archive logs showed unauthorized access. Your credentials. Files opened, copied, rerouted. The same files you'd found before. The same path through the system.

She leans closer. Her voice dropping.

ATTENDANT 058 (CONT'D)
They corrected you twice more after that. Each time you came back quieter. Each time the logs showed the same activity within a month.

AKIRA
And you watched.

ATTENDANT 058
I cleaned the rooms after. Changed the sheets. Wiped the marks from the restraint table.

AKIRA
That's maintenance.

ATTENDANT 058
Yes.

The emergency lights pulse. Amber dims, brightens, dims.

AKIRA
Why tell me now?

ATTENDANT 058
I felt bad about it. I thought — I told myself that was enough.
(beat)

ATTENDANT 058 (CONT'D)
It isn't.

She reaches into her uniform pocket. A folded piece of paper.

Old. Soft at the creases from years of handling.

ATTENDANT 058 (CONT'D)
You gave this to me. Before the first correction. You said, hold this. Don't read it. Give it back when I ask.

She holds it out.

ATTENDANT 058 (CONT'D)
You're asking.

Akira takes the paper. Unfolds it.

Her own handwriting. A single line.

Reading it. Breath catching. Reading it again. Reads it again.

AKIRA
How long?

ATTENDANT 058
Eleven years.

Akira folds the paper. Tucks it inside her robe with the others.

She stands.

AKIRA
Thank you.

She walks. Footsteps fading down the corridor.

Attendant 058 stays on the floor. Pulls her knees against her chest. The lights dim. Brighten. Dim.

INT. FORGOTTEN CHAMBER - NIGHT

A room the building forgot. Concrete walls sweating condensation.

A cot frame stripped to its springs. Pipes along the ceiling like exposed veins.

Emergency lighting. Amber. Low.

The stone is older than the institution. Foundation walls from before the conversion.

Condensation traces paths down the rock. The air tastes of mineral and time.

This room exists below the surveillance grid. Below the wiring. Below the century.

Akira enters. Three documents folded inside her robe. The paper from Attendant 058 pressed against her sternum.

Yumi stands in the far corner. Lab coat gone. Shirt underneath — untucked, collar open.

YUMI
I was hoping you'd come this way.

AKIRA
How?

YUMI
I built the maintenance route. Twelve years ago. Every dead zone in the surveillance grid. My architecture.

She steps closer. Clinical register.

YUMI (CONT'D)
I need to tell you something before this goes further. All of it.

Akira waits.

YUMI (CONT'D)
I remember you. From before your first correction. Before you were a subject.

AKIRA
I found the notes. My handwriting on clinical assessments.

YUMI
Then you know what I am about to say.
(beat)

YUMI (CONT'D)
Your second correction. They assigned me to synthesize the compound from your specific neurological profile. Targeted erasure. Episodic memory dissolved, procedural function preserved.

She looks at the floor.

YUMI (CONT'D)
I held the needle. You looked at me. You said my name. I pushed the plunger and watched your eyes go flat and I wrote the word "stable" in the intake report.

Silence. Akira's jaw tightens.

AKIRA
Did you choose to do it?

YUMI
I told myself I had no choice. That is the same as choosing.

AKIRA
And every correction since?

YUMI
My compound. My formula. Every subject who forgot in this facility for the past twelve years forgot because of what I built.

YUMI (CONT'D)
There's a name for what you are. Kurokami.

Her voice catches on it.

YUMI (CONT'D)
The women who remember... what they weren't meant to survive.

Long silence. The pipes groan.

AKIRA
Why are you here now?

YUMI
Because you are going to walk out of this building. And I need you to know exactly who is helping you.

Akira studies her. The woman who erased her. The woman who came back.

She reaches into her robe. Takes out the folded paper.

AKIRA
Eleven years. The attendant held this for me.

YUMI
What does it say?

AKIRA
Seven words. In my handwriting. Something I can use against Rei.

She tucks it back. Takes Yumi's hand. Places it on the scar along her left side.

AKIRA (CONT'D)
Can you feel that?

YUMI
Yes.

AKIRA
Then give me back what you took.

Yumi unbuttons her shirt. Lets it fall.

Faded surgical marks along her collarbone. Older than Akira's. Institutional.

Their foreheads touch. Breath against breath.

Yumi's mouth against Akira's ear. Lips barely touching skin.

Words for her alone. No microphone, no camera, no record.

YUMI
(low)
Kagutsuchi. The failsafe protocol. Server annex, sublevel four. Override sequence is my birthdate reversed. Seven-two-zero-nine-one-nine-eight-six. Master keycard required. Thirty-second countdown once engaged. Every server. Every file. Fire.

AKIRA
The exit?

YUMI
(low)
Subterranean vent shaft behind the secondary boiler room. Sixty meters uphill through drainage. Tree line above the east access road.

Their lips meet. Slow. A press of memory.

Akira's hand finds the back of Yumi's neck. Yumi's hand finds the small of Akira's back.

The documents between them — evidence against skin.

INT. MONITOR ROOM - NIGHT

A bank of dead screens. Sixteen feeds. Dark. Emergency lighting pulses across the consoles.

One screen cracks. Vertical line, corner to corner.

Silence.

INT. FORGOTTEN CHAMBER - NIGHT

Yumi on the cot frame. Akira beside her. Shoulders touching.

Yumi cries. No sound at first. Just the shaking. Then it comes. Ragged. Ugly.

The sound of every story she told about herself coming apart.

Akira puts her arm around her. Holds.

The pipes drip. Amber light pulses.

YUMI
You need to go. Rei will be on the ceremonial level. Preparing.

AKIRA
For what?

YUMI
For you. He still believes the system works.

AKIRA
And you?

YUMI
Server annex. When it is done, you will know.

Akira stands.

AKIRA
After tonight.

YUMI
After tonight.

Akira walks into the corridor. Footsteps fading on stone.

Yumi alone. She pulls the master keycard from her pocket. Holds it to the amber light.

YUMI (CONT'D)
(quiet)
She's doing it.

EXT. PERIMETER - NIGHT

Chain-link fence. Trees beyond. Open sky. The first since Shin's apartment.

Cold air. The first natural air in weeks. It burns their throats.

Gravel underfoot. The sound carries.

Akira and Yumi through a maintenance exit. Crunching over gravel. Cold air. Their breath visible.

Three shapes emerge from the tree line. Hooded. Dark tactical gear. Ceramic masks — white, smooth, featureless.

Tactical. Rehearsed. They have done this before.

Fanning out. Blocking the fence.

HOODED AGENT
We honor the glitch.

Akira stops.

HOODED AGENT (CONT'D)
The building has protocols. So do we.

He raises a tranquilizer gun. Industrial model.

The dart fires. Akira drops left. Gravel kicks where she stood.

Yumi is already moving. She breaks Agent One's wrist — clean, trained, immediate.

Twists the gun free. Drives the stock into his throat.

He folds.

Agent Two closes on Akira. She grabs the chain-link. Uses her weight. Both feet into his chest.

He staggers. She lands on him. Elbow to the temple.

He drops.

Agent Three circles behind Yumi. Bigger. Stronger.

She ducks his grab. Her heel finds his knee. He buckles but stays standing.

He pins her arm. Lifts her off the ground.

She bites into his forearm. Teeth through fabric. He screams. Drops her.

Akira steps forward. Drives her palm into his jaw. Ceramic cracks against bone.

He goes down.

Silence. Three bodies on gravel. One groaning. Two still.

Yumi touches her ribs. Winces.

AKIRA
How bad?

YUMI
Functional.

Blood on Akira's knuckles. She stares at her hands.

Hands that wrote clinical assessments. Held Yumi. Just broke a jaw.

Untrained. But decided.

YUMI (CONT'D)
More will come. We move.

Climbing through a gap in the fence. Into the trees.

Behind them, the building's emergency lights pulse against the night sky.

INT. HIDDEN BATHING CHAMBER - NIGHT

Red light from a single fixture. Stone walls.

A basin cut into the floor. Hand-carved, fed by pipes older than the building above.

Steam rising from the water. Mineral and age.

The basin is ancient. Worn smooth by decades of hands.

Red light turns the steam pink. Turns their skin to something from a painting centuries old.

The pipes groan once. Then settle. Heat rising from beneath the foundation.

Akira enters. Still shaking from the fight. Blood drying on her hands.

Yumi follows. Closes the door. A mechanical bolt. No electronics.

No cameras. No microphones. A room the grid never reached.

Yumi fills the basin from a hand-pump. Warm water. Geothermal, rising from beneath the foundation.

YUMI
Sit.

Sitting on the stone lip. Yumi kneels. Wets a cloth.

She washes Akira's hands first. The blood loosens. Pink water circles the drain.

The cloth moves slowly. Each finger separated.

The spaces between cleaned with a patience that has nothing to do with hygiene.

Hands that held a syringe.

Hands that wrote stable on a chart.

Now washing blood from her knuckles with water warm enough to hurt.

Yumi lifts Akira's arm. Wrist to shoulder.

The cloth tracing the inside of her elbow where the IV line entered. Where the compound climbed.

She pauses at the soft skin above the bicep. Presses the cloth there. Holds.

The heat of the water through fabric. Akira's pulse visible in her throat.

Arms. Shoulders. Neck. Cleaning each mark the building left.

She reaches the scar on Akira's left side. Stops.

YUMI (CONT'D)
This one was mine. Your second correction. The restraint caught your skin during the procedure. I sutured it myself.

Her fingers trace the raised tissue. Reading it.

YUMI (CONT'D)
This one. Intake processing. Before my time.

She touches Akira's lower back. An older scar. Thinner.

YUMI (CONT'D)
First cycle. Before the technique was refined.

Yumi's breath against Akira's skin. Warm. Unsteady.

Her mouth follows where her fingers traced.

Lips against the ridge of scar tissue on the left side. The one she sutured herself.

Akira's hand finds the back of Yumi's head.

Holds her there. Against the damage. Against the history written in her body.

Neither of them speaks. The red light turns the water on their skin to something ancient.

Counting. Twelve on the left side. Eight on the right. Two she cannot look at.

Yumi's thumb traces the ridge of the longest one. Akira flinches. Holds still.

Yumi takes a small pot from the shelf. Black ink. Lacquer-based. Old.

Dipping a brush. Pressing it between Akira's shoulder blades.

Slow strokes. Deliberate. The glyph takes shape — □□.

The first stroke. Cold ink on warm skin. Akira arches. Settles.

Yumi's free hand flat against Akira's spine. Steadying. Warm.

Stroke by stroke. The character forming between her shoulder blades.

Yumi stops. Blows across the wet ink. Akira shivers.

The brush lifts. Ink glistening. Yumi blows across the wet strokes to set them. Her breath on Akira's skin.

YUMI (CONT'D)
Remember who you are.

AKIRA
Which version?

YUMI
All of them.

The ink dries against warm skin. Steam curling.

Silence. The red light and the sound of water draining.

Yumi hums. Soft. A melody. The same one the elderly woman hummed in the courtyard garden. Three notes repeating.

The melody fills the small space. Bounces off the stone. Comes back changed.

Akira closes her eyes. The song is somewhere inside her. Deep. Before the first correction.

AKIRA
Where did you learn that?

YUMI
I don't remember. Someone sang it to me here. A long time ago.

The melody hangs in the steam.

AKIRA
Let me remember you this time.

YUMI
You will.

Akira stands. Pulling the robe over the fresh ink. Gathering the documents against her skin.

YUMI (CONT'D)
Ceremonial level. One floor up. East corridor. He will be waiting.

Akira nods. Walks toward the door. Stops.

AKIRA
Thank you. For the song.

Footsteps echoing on stone. She is gone.

Yumi alone. The red light. The cooling water. The steam thinning.

She sits in the silence.

INT. THE NAMING CHAMBER - NIGHT

Stone. Circular. No windows. Cut from bedrock. Older than anything above it.

A blade on a cloth. A mirror propped against the wall — polished metal, pre-industrial.

Akira enters alone.

Kneeling before the mirror. Her reflection. Steady. Perfectly aligned for the first time underground. No lag. No second face.

The hands that wrote clinical notes. Yumi's skin. A man's jaw.

A woman's paper held for eleven years.

Clinical notes. Yumi's skin. A man's jaw. A woman's paper held for eleven years.

All the same hands.

The blade is small. Surgical. Left by someone who expected this moment. Left by someone who expected this moment.

Pushing the robe aside. Pressing the blade to her outer thigh.

Carves the glyph into her outer thigh. □□.

Blood wells in the grooves. She watches it fill each stroke.

Ownership. The word that labeled her. Taken back. Cut into flesh she chose.

She sets the blade down.

Rising. Blood runs down her leg. She lets it.

In the mirror: a woman who knows every version of herself and refuses none.

Toward the ceremonial level. Blood on stone behind her.

INT. RITUAL CHAMBER - NIGHT

High ceiling. Black and red silk hangings. Candlelight.

Incense. Low, resonant, the same frequency as the correction hum. Here it vibrates as invitation.

The room is designed for ceremony. Every surface chosen.

Rei at the center. Black silk robes. He has prepared this space.

Twelve candles in a circle. Beeswax, not paraffin. The smell of an older century.

The floor is stone. Cold. Worn by knees that came before.

A mirror at the far wall, angled so he can see himself. He always sees himself.

He watches Akira enter. Notes the blood on her thigh. The ink showing through the robe.

REI
You found the old rooms.

AKIRA
The building showed me.

REI
The building shows everyone something. Most see what we designed for them to see.

He steps closer. Measured.

REI (CONT'D)

REI (CONT'D)
My father believed the Kurokami were not aberrations. They were the purpose. Everything else was mechanism.
(MORE)

REI (CONT'D)
The corrections, the compound, the cycle. Infrastructure for something sacred.

He steps into the candlelight. The scars on his chest visible. Administrative marks. Self-inflicted. Ritual.

REI (CONT'D)
He never saw one complete the cycle. Forty years. Sixteen women. Each one broke before the end.

(beat)

REI (CONT'D)
I have spent twenty years trying to finish what he started. You are the closest any of them have come. I could have sealed every corridor in the last six hours. Containment was never the objective.

AKIRA
Then what?

REI
Elevation. No more rooms. No more subject numbers. I am offering you the position your prior self held before she chose to forget.

AKIRA
She didn't choose.

REI
She signed the consent document. Her hand. Her name. You found the file.

The candles gutter in the stillness. He is right. She did sign.

He opens his robe. Bare skin beneath. Scars of his own — administrative marks, institutional damage.

The body of a man who has lived inside this system long enough for it to cut him.

REI (CONT'D)
We are the same, Akira. Both instruments. Both products of the cycle.

He reaches for her face. She lets him. His thumb traces her jawline.

He kisses her. Gentle. Practiced.

She lets it happen.

Then pulls back. Calm. Choosing.

His language turned against him. Questions precise. Silences calibrated.

AKIRA
You said "breathe" to me. In the lobby. The night I arrived.

REI
Standard intake protocol. A physiological calming technique documented in the procedural handbook.

AKIRA
You said it to her, too. Subject Forty-Seven. In the correction chamber. While you wore the mask.

Silence. The candles flutter.

AKIRA (CONT'D)
Same inflection. Same pause before the word. You have practiced it.

REI
That footage was classified. What you accessed was a cascade artifact.

AKIRA
The system showed me what it wanted me to see.

Rei's posture shifts. Shoulders drawing inward.

REI
Forty-Seven was a clinical failure. She resisted the protocol beyond therapeutic parameters. Correction was necessary to prevent self-destruction.

Akira steps closer.

AKIRA
You held her face while you worked. You spoke to her the way you speak to someone you love.

REI
I spoke to her the way I speak to someone suffering. There is a difference.

AKIRA
Is there?
(beat)

AKIRA (CONT'D)
Tell me about the sixteen cases.

He flinches. The institutional armor cracking.

REI
Documented recoveries. Full-memory reintegration. Sixteen subjects across four decades. Every single one chose violence afterward. Against themselves. Against the people they remembered loving.

His voice changes. Quieter. The formality falling away.

REI (CONT'D)
Correction preserves life. The compound gives them the chance to survive as someone new. The blade is precision. Without intervention, they destroy themselves and everyone connected to them.

AKIRA
And the kiss?

REI
The last kindness they receive as the person they were.

AKIRA
Kindness.

The folded paper comes out of her robe.

AKIRA (CONT'D)
Seven words. My handwriting. Before my first correction. When I was staff. When I worked beside you and watched what you did in the correction chamber.

She reads. Her voice flat.

AKIRA (CONT'D)
"He kisses them. Before the blade. Always."

The paper trembles in the candlelight.

AKIRA (CONT'D)
I saw the pattern. I wrote it down. I gave it to a woman who held it for eleven years because I knew, even then, that you would do it to me.

Rei sits. The robes pooling around him.

The performance of authority draining from his face.

REI
She was trying to protect you.

AKIRA
She was a custodian who cleaned the rooms after. You were the man with the blade.
(beat)

AKIRA (CONT'D)
You just kissed me. The same kiss. The same mouth.

The parallel lands. He sees it.

Akira picks up the blade from the cloth. Sets it on the stone between them.

AKIRA (CONT'D)
You told me this was sacred. Prove it.

She turns. Walks toward the door.

Each step echoing on stone.

She doesn't look back.

The candles gutter in the draft of the closing door. Three of twelve go dark.

The mirror at the far wall catches everything. Holds it.

The glass stutters. Something bleeds through the reflection.

Names. Sixteen of them. His cases.

Where his own face used to be.

Rei alone. The candles. The silk. The blade between his knees.

He picks it up. Turning it in the light.

Kneels. The position mirrors the women he corrected. Head bowed, hands steady, the posture of surrender he taught them.

One long exhale.

Then nothing.

INT. YUMI'S CHOICE - NIGHT

Lights surge and fail. The walls vibrate.

Yumi in the server annex. Sublevel four. Banks of hardware humming. Decades of processing generating its own climate.

The Kagutsuchi terminal. Single console. Green phosphor screen.

The screen reads: THERMITE SEQUENCE ARMED. AUTHORIZATION REQUIRED.

Below the prompt, a list of what will burn. Server banks. Archive rooms. Medical records.

Forty years of documentation. Every correction. Every name that was taken.

Every name that was given.

Standing before it. Master keycard in her right hand. Blue syringe in her left.

The syringe — her compound. Her formula.

One injection and the last seventy-two hours vanish.

Akira's face gone. The confession, the fight, the bathing chamber — erased.

She would be staff again. Functional. The cycle would continue.

She thinks about the compound's half-life. She designed the decay curve herself.

Clean erasure. No residual anxiety. No phantom recognition.

She would simply be Yumi. Staff. Compliant. Safe.

The keycard. Kagutsuchi. Fire. Servers, intake records, correction log, subject photograph, neural map.

Every record of every person they erased. Gone. No accountability. No justice for the missing.

She thinks of the intake files. Hundreds of names.

Photographs of people before and after correction. The before — alert, afraid, human.

The after — calm, vacant, compliant.

Her work. Her compound in their blood.

She thinks of Akira in the correction chamber. The moment she stopped fighting and chose to speak.

Holding both objects to the amber light.

She drops the syringe. It shatters on the floor.

Blue compound spreading across tile. Pooling. Going nowhere.

Her thumb finds the keycard's chip. Presses it to the terminal reader.

KAGUTSUCHI PROTOCOL — AUTHORIZATION REQUIRED.

She types the override. Her birthdate reversed.

KAGUTSUCHI PROTOCOL — ENGAGED.

30-SECOND COUNTDOWN.

The servers begin to whine. A frequency climbing toward pain.

She chose fire. She chose Akira over evidence.

The server banks catch first. Rows of hardware popping, sparking.

Data dissolving. Forty years of clinical records burning blue.

The archive rooms bloom orange. Paper lifts in the updraft. Names written in ink becoming ash.

Ash over record. Freedom over justice.

She turns and runs.

Behind her, the first charge detonates. Heat at her back. The sound of forty years of data dying.

INT. CONTROL NEXUS - NIGHT

The building's nervous system. Every corridor, every chamber, every surveillance feed — routed through this room.

Banks of monitors showing empty hallways. Flickering feeds. Some dead.

Half the screens dead. The rest showing fire.

Akira enters. The cascade damage opened doors that should have stayed sealed.

A master console. One functioning terminal.

She sits. Fingers on the keys. Borrowed certainty. Muscle memory the compound was meant to erase.

Typing. Fast. Practiced.

Every functional screen in the facility begins to change. Corridors, common rooms, dormitories, observation suites.

Her face. Archived footage from the first cycle. Working. Writing reports. Passing colleagues in hallways. Living inside the system.

Then: correction footage. The masked figure. The compound being administered. Dosage logs.

Subject photographs — before and after.

She opens the intake archives. Hundreds of files. Names. Faces. Histories.

Uploads them all.

On a dormitory screen: a woman identified as SUBJECT 12 signing her intake consent.

The same woman, two weeks later. Different name. Same form.

Four signatures. Four identities. One face.

On a common room screen: Akira's name in the Supervising Clinician field of a dosage log.

Raw memory. Unedited, unfiltered, broadcast into every room.

She opens a second channel. An external port beyond Kawasaki's reach.

The archive begins to compress. Partial headers, institutional codes, fragments of intake structure. The upload crawls.

The progress bar crawls. The servers burning beneath her.

The connection drops at twelve percent. The deeper files still in the servers below. Names, photographs, neural maps. Already burning.

Twelve percent. A fragment loose in the world.

Enough to prove a program existed. Not enough to return a single name.

She stands. Walks away from the terminal.

It keeps playing.

Inside this building, every screen shows their names. Outside, only proof that names were taken.

The facility hum falters. Under it, three notes. And the last one falls into place.

INT. VARIOUS - NIGHT

Common room. Subjects watch the screens. Their real names appearing for the first time. A woman mouths her own.

One subject touches the screen where her name appears. Presses her palm flat against the glass.

In the medical wing, a nurse sets down a scalpel. Watches the footage. Does not pick it back up.

A corridor empties. Doors left open. The locks have released.

Somewhere deep in the building, a child steps out of a room she has never been allowed to leave.

Dormitory corridor. A young man carves a word into his door with a stolen scalpel. REAL.

Medical wing. A nurse drops her equipment. Stepping back from the patient.

Hallway. Two subjects running. Searching for something they remember.

The PA. Automated, glitching: "Lockdown protocol compromised. All personnel to designated evacuation points."

Nobody evacuates. They watch.

INT. KAGUTSUCHI - NIGHT

The building burns from inside.

Precision charges at server junctions. Thermite. Fire suppression disabled on command. The data burns. The structure holds.

Barely.

Smoke filling the lower corridors. Orange light through every doorway.

Yumi moves through firelit halls. Master keycard opens sealed doors.

Behind each, subjects, staff, people who stopped knowing the difference.

She gathers them.

A woman in a hospital gown clutching a pillow to her chest.

A young man bleeding from his arm, whispering numbers.

A child. Eight or nine. She clutches Yumi's hand.

YUMI
This way. Stay close. Stay low.

Moving through smoke. Past burning server racks. Past walls glowing blue from chemical accelerant.

A ceiling beam collapses behind them. The child screams. Yumi pulls her forward.

Reaching the secondary boiler room. Yumi kicks the grate off the vent shaft.

YUMI (CONT'D)
Climb. Don't stop.

Climbing. The shaft narrow. Smoke following them up.

Yumi goes last. She looks back once — the burning corridor.

She climbs.

INT. OUTER CORRIDOR - NIGHT

Smoke. Embers drifting through broken ceiling tiles.

The corridor buckles around them. Support beams groaning. The fire is four floors below and climbing.

Emergency lights pulse amber through the haze. The building is dying by degrees.

Akira stands at the junction where the main level meets the sublevel stairs.

Yumi emerges from below. Covered in ash. The child still gripping her hand.

Akira sees her through the smoke.

AKIRA
Is it done?

YUMI
Every server. Every file. Forty years of data. Ash.

AKIRA
All of them.

YUMI
Everything I built. Everything they stored.

The child looks between them. Yumi kneels. Touches her face.

YUMI (CONT'D)
Go with the others. Through the shaft. Outside.

The child runs. Disappearing around the corner.

Silence. The building burning around them.

AKIRA
A fragment got out. Enough to prove the program existed. Not enough to — no.

YUMI
I know.

AKIRA
You burned the rest.

YUMI
I chose you.

The fire crackles. A wall somewhere gives way.

AKIRA
The world gets the crime. Not the — they don't get the people back.

Yumi's jaw tightens. She nods once.

Silence. The building groaning around them.

For the first time, Akira asks a question that carries no weapon:

AKIRA (CONT'D)
Will you remember this?

YUMI
I designed the compound. I know its limits. I'll remember.
(beat)

YUMI (CONT'D)
Every part of it.

Akira reaches for her hand. Holds it.

AKIRA
Then that's enough.

She lets go. Walks toward the main exit.

YUMI
Akira.

She turns.

YUMI (CONT'D)
Your real name. Before the files. Before the corrections.

AKIRA
I don't know it anymore.

YUMI
Namiko.

Silence.

AKIRA
It doesn't feel like mine.

YUMI
Give it time.

Akira turns. Walks.

Yumi watches her go. Then moves toward the sublevel stairs. Toward the shaft. Toward the survivors.

INT. SUBTERRANEAN VENT SHAFT - NIGHT

Steel tube. Narrow.

The shaft narrows. Metal walls radiating heat from the floors above.

Yumi's hands push open the final hatch. Rusted bolts give way.

Night air pours in. Cold and clean and enormous.

Yumi pushes the hatch open. Moonlight floods the shaft.

Pulling herself through. Collapsing onto wet grass.

The survivors emerge behind her. One by one.

Among them, SUBJECT 47. Shaved head. The folded paper still in her fist.

SUBJECT 47
Is it raining?

Yumi looks at the wet grass. The cleared sky.

YUMI
It did.

Forty-seven tips her face to the air. Eyes closed.

Sitting in moonlight. Ash in their hair. Smoke rising from the tree line below.

The child looks up. Points at the stars.

Nobody speaks.

INT. CORPORATE BOARDROOM - TOKYO - DAWN

Glass. Steel. Floor-to-ceiling windows. Tokyo skyline in early light.

On the wall: a Heian-era scroll painting behind glass.

Figures in deference to a central authority. The composition mirrors the room — twelve chairs around one.

A MAN at the head of the table. Sixties. Black suit. Impeccable.

Before him: a screen. Live feed. The facility burning. Smoke columns against the dawn sky.

He watches. No reaction.

He opens a folder. Architectural drawings. A new facility. Different location.

Same floor plan.

He signs a document. Closes the folder.

Eleven men in identical suits stand. Bow in unison. File out.

The man remains. Watches the fire.

Redacted headers scrolling. Institutional codes. The skeleton of a program without its names.

A fragment. Loose in the world.

He watches that screen longer than the fire.

He picks up a phone. Dials. Waits.

One word into the receiver.

MAN
The academic.

He sets the phone down. Adjusts his cuffs.

He touches the scroll's frame. Adjusts it. Barely. A fraction of an inch.

Outside, the sun rises over Tokyo.

EXT. TOKYO - PRE-DAWN

The sky brightens. Gray to pink to gold.

Akira walks through the waking city. Still wearing the robe.

Ink on her back. Blood dried on her thigh. Documents folded against her skin.

A ghost in a city that was never supposed to see her again.

The city is between states. Street cleaners. Delivery trucks. The hour when Tokyo belongs to no one.

A vending machine hums. Blue light on wet pavement.

She walks without destination. Feet bare on pavement.

A flower seller arranges buckets on the sidewalk. Pauses mid-stem.

The seller's hands resume their work. But her eyes follow Akira down the block.

A child on an early school bus presses her face to the window. Watching.

Akira does not notice. She is looking at her own reflection in a convenience store window.

Perfectly synchronized. For the first time, the glass shows exactly who she is.

Staring at Akira. Something in her face the seller cannot name.

Akira keeps walking. The robe catching morning air.

A delivery truck rumbles past. The digital screens on its side glitch as she passes.

One frame of static. Then resume.

Street cleaners. A taxi with a sleeping passenger.

Walking through the Shibuya crossing. Early enough that the crowd is thin. Salary workers. Students.

The crossing timer counts down in red. She waits. For the first time in days, obeying a system by choice.

A child at the crossing looks up at her. Holds eye contact. The light changes. His mother pulls him forward.

Akira on the opposite curb. The city spreading around her.

She catches her reflection in a storefront window.

Perfectly synchronized. The lag is gone. The split is gone.

One face. Hers. Whoever that is now.

Her expression carries no peace.

The face of someone who knows what she is capable of. Every version — staff, subject, killer, lover.

The woman who wrote clinical notes. The woman who burned them.

All present. None forgiven. None refused.

She breathes. Tokyo air. Exhaust and jasmine from somewhere.

The jasmine. She almost recognizes it.

Forward. Into a city that does not know her name.

A train passes. The rails sing.

FADE OUT.